Eight Questions Families Ask When Mom's Care Arrangement Is Working and They'd Like to Understand Why

Plain, general answers about backup help and looking again, and where to take the questions that are about Mom herself.

Things are going well for Mom, which can make it feel odd to ask questions about her support. Other families wonder about the same things. These are the eight that come up most, answered in general terms.

None of the answers is about Mom in particular. Where a question needs someone who knows her, the answer says who to ask.

1 Everything is working. Why write any of it down?

Because a working arrangement lives in several people's heads, and each holds a different part. The National Institute on Aging says the conversation about sharing care is most productive when there is not an emergency, and that the best time to plan is before a person needs extensive help. A calm week is simply an easier week to write in. Doing it doesn't mean you expect anything to change. [1] [2]

> **ASK A PROFESSIONAL WHEN** something about Mom's health concerns you now. Tell her doctor what you've noticed. That's a conversation, not a line on a list.

2 How do we tell which parts of Mom's week depend on one person?

List each thing someone does for her, small jobs included, and beside it write who else could do it. Where you can't name anyone, write “only them.” The National Institute on Aging suggests a question to start from: other than the main helper, who can step in to help occasionally? A task marked “only them” is something to ask about. It isn't a finding. [1]

> **ASK A PROFESSIONAL WHEN** a task that rests on one person involves her health, such as her medicines. Ask her doctor or pharmacist what a second person would need to know.

3 What counts as support that's missing today?

Something Mom needs or wants help with that nobody does yet, or that gets done only some of the time. To go through her week in order, the National Institute on Aging's list of help at home is a plain place to start: personal care, household chores, meals, money management, health care, transportation and safety. Company and the things she enjoys count too. Write what happens now, in neutral words, and keep it apart from anything that only might come up later. [3] [4]

> **ASK A PROFESSIONAL WHEN** you can't tell whether something you've noticed is a need at all. Describe what you saw to her doctor or your care consultant, and let them say.

4 Aunt Carol would step in if we needed her. Isn't that a backup?

It is once she has said so. The Family Caregiver Alliance's first step for a backup is to think about who would most likely help, then talk with them about what might be needed and their willingness to step in. Until that conversation has happened, the entry beside her name is “assumed.” The same page tells caregivers without a backup plan that they are not alone, and that many handle everything themselves. [5]

> **ASK A PROFESSIONAL WHEN** the family can't agree on who to ask, or someone has said no and you're not sure what that leaves. Bring the list as it stands to your care consultant.

5 How do we raise this without upsetting Mom, or making the neighbor feel checked up on?

Say plainly what you're doing: writing down what works, so nobody is guessing. Start with Mom. The CDC's guide to care plans says to begin the conversation with the person herself, and the National Institute on Aging says that, with her permission, you could contact the people who see her regularly. With the neighbor, ask about the routine: “Could you show me how the appointment days work?” [6] [2]

> **ASK A PROFESSIONAL WHEN** Mom would rather something stayed off the page. That's hers to decide. Note that it's her wish, and mention it to your care consultant as an open question.

6 One of us does most of it and says it's no trouble. Does that belong on the list?

Yes, as a fact about the arrangement and not a comment on anyone. The National Institute on Aging says no one can be expected to do everything, and that a main caregiver may be hesitant to ask for help or a break. Its page for caregivers quotes a familiar reply, “Thanks, but I'm fine,” and says accepting help isn't always easy. Ask each helper what their part takes in an ordinary week, and write down what they say in their words. [1] [7]

> **ASK A PROFESSIONAL WHEN** a helper tells you their part has become more than they can keep doing. Write down what they said and bring it to your care consultant. It isn't something to settle on the list.

7 What should make us look at this again?

Changes you could actually notice. The CDC suggests updating a written care plan every year, or more often when health or medicines change; the National Institute on Aging adds changes in family members' availability, and the Family Caregiver Alliance adds changes in family members' own lives. Write a short list of your own under three headings: Mom, the people who help her, and the house. A change on it means reread the page, and nothing more than that. [6] [1] [8]

> **ASK A PROFESSIONAL WHEN** the change is in Mom's health or her medicines. Tell her doctor what you noticed and when.

8 If we find a gap, does that mean Mom isn't managing, or needs more care?

Not by itself. A gap on a family's list is a line that says nobody does this yet, or only one person could. It describes the arrangement. It doesn't measure Mom. Whether anything should change is for her and the professionals who assess her, with your list in front of them.

> **ASK A PROFESSIONAL WHEN** you want to know what a line on the list means for Mom. Bring the list to her doctor or your care consultant.

What this guide doesn't do

It doesn't answer any question about Mom herself. Whether her arrangement is enough, what she may need later and whether anything should change all depend on someone who knows her and has assessed her.

Ready for the next step?

You have plain answers to the questions that felt odd to raise while everything is fine. The care interview is where the questions become about Mom: it goes through her daily life area by area, including the parts nobody thinks to mention, and turns your answers into a Family Care Profile you can bring to any care conversation.

Create Your Free Family Care Profile ›

WHERE THIS COMES FROM

1. National Institute on Aging, Sharing Caregiving Responsibilities
2. National Institute on Aging, Does an Older Adult in Your Life Need Help?
3. National Institute on Aging, Aging in Place: Growing Older at Home
4. National Institute on Aging, Participating in Activities You Enjoy As You Age
5. Family Caregiver Alliance, Smart Caregiving by FCA: Backup Planning
6. Centers for Disease Control and Prevention, Steps for Creating and Maintaining a Care Plan
7. National Institute on Aging, Taking Care of Yourself: Tips for Caregivers
8. Family Caregiver Alliance, Holding a Family Meeting